

Street Food in Southeast Asia

Street food both scares and entices visitors to Southeast Asia, as worries about hygiene battle with the alluring sights and smells of the dishes on display. Put your fears aside and eat like the locals; you'll experience the best-value food Southeast Asia has to offer.

VIETNAM

Fresh and lighter than many cuisines in the region, Vietnamese cooking draws heavily on herbs, chili peppers, and lime. The street food of Vietnam is a frequent contender for favorite among travelers to the region, and rightly so.

Hoi An

Look beyond the Old Quarter's stunning buildings and you'll find excellent street food virtually everywhere. Keep an eye out for the moving vendors, such as the women who balance restaurants across their shoulders and the town's steamed bun (*banh bao*) merchant, who blasts pop music from his cart. Head north out of the Old Quarter for fantastic *banh mi*.

Old Quarter, Hanoi

From the moment the sun rises, the Old Quarter in Hanoi comes alive, with each corner seemingly bringing a new street-dining experience — pull up a plastic chair, order some *pho* or *banh cuon* (rice-flour pancakes stuffed with pork and wood-ear mushroom), and dig in.

Bac Ha

An overnight train plus a 2-hour minibus ride from Hanoi, Bac Ha's Sunday market is perhaps only for the dedicated traveler. But it's worth the effort when you sit down to eat pork noodle soup among the local Flower Hmong tribe, surrounded by a carnival of color that will stay with you for life.

THAILAND

Fiery from red hot chili peppers and pungent with shrimp paste and *nam pla* (fish sauce), Thailand's food is well known around the world, but its own streets still throw up lots of surprises, from fried cockroaches to sour orange curry and local sausages.

Chinatown, Bangkok

By day the main street of Bangkok's Chinatown is the city's busy gold-trading area, but by nightfall it is packed with street food vendors. Hungry visitors here snap up dishes such as *pla pao* (char-grilled fish), *tom yum koong* (the shrimp version of the sour and spicy soup), and *goong pao* (barbecued shrimp). For impressive displays of fresh seafood on ice, head to the T&K food stand on the corner of Thanon Phadung Dao and the Yaowarat Road.

Silom Road, Bangkok

This area is the business hub of the city and is home to many street stands at each end of the day. For a taste of real Bangkok — on many levels — get up early and go for the morning shift, when the road is filled to bursting point with hawkers plying their trade to the rat-race of workers. The delicious deep-fried pork and sticky rice is always a favorite.

Warorot Market, Chiang Mai

When the sun sets in Chiang Mai, the food vendors move into the roads around Tom Lamyai flower market near the river's pedestrian bridge. Try the northern Thai sausages and, if you're feeling adventurous, some of the deep-fried insects.

MALAYSIA

Malaysia is a wonderful meeting of cultures. Large groups of indigenous Malay, Chinese, and Indians have influenced each other's cuisines over the years, sharing techniques and ingredients to create unique dishes.

Gurney Drive Night Market, Penang

Persiaran Gurney (Gurney Drive), Georgetown
Penang is famed among Malaysians for its food, and this night market is the largest in the city. It opens until late and is busy until the end, packed with locals and tourists alike. The famous fried chicken skin and *asam laksa* noodles are must-tries.

Jalan Alor

Golden Triangle, Kuala Lumpur

In Kuala Lumpur's Golden Triangle, someone thrusts a menu at you approximately every five steps. The food here is a fantastic introduction to the Chinese dishes of Malaysia, such as *pan mee* (See On the Menu, right). A roadside durian fruit makes a strong-smelling end to the meal that you'll either love or hate.

